Experiencing Chineseness:

A Comparative Study of Sense of Place in London and Manchester Chinatowns

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Declaration

I declare that this dissertation was composed by myself, that the work contained herein is my own except where explicitly stated otherwise in the text, and that this work has not been submitted for any other degree or professional qualification except as specified.



Junyu Liao (25928666)
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Abstract

Chinatowns are often understood as visible representations of Chinese culture within foreign cities. However, their identities are not fixed and may be experienced differently depending on their historical development, urban context and spatial organisation. This dissertation explores how sense of place is produced within British Chinatowns through a comparative study of London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown.

The research uses a qualitative comparative approach combining literature review, walking observation, photography, voice recordings and autoethnographic reflection. Rather than comparing the two Chinatowns by the amount of visible Chinese cultural representation, the study focuses on how cultural identity is experienced through everyday urban conditions. Particular attention is given to boundaries, movement patterns, commercial continuity and linguistic landscapes, as well as how these elements are encountered during walking.

The findings show that London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown produce different experiences of Chineseness. In London, a stronger sense of immersion develops through continuous commercial activity, pedestrian movement and visual continuity along the streets. Manchester Chinatown creates a more immediate sense of recognition through the Chinese archway and other cultural markers. These differences are shaped not only by the internal characteristics of each Chinatown, but also by their relationship with the wider urban environments around them.

By examining Chinatowns as lived urban experiences rather than fixed cultural enclaves, this research contributes to discussions of sense of place, linguistic landscape and urban identity. It argues that Chineseness is continuously produced through interactions between space, movement, memory and everyday activities.

Key Words

Sense of Place; Chinatown; Chineseness; Urban Identity; Linguistic Landscape; Autoethnography

1. Introduction

Chinatowns are often understood as visible expressions of Chinese migration, cultural identity and urban diversity within Western cities. Existing studies have explored themes such as diaspora, ethnicity, commerce and cultural representation. However, less attention has been given to how different Chinatowns are experienced spatially and how they generate different senses of place.

This dissertation focuses on London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown. Although both are recognised as important British Chinatowns, they emerged within different urban contexts and appear to produce different spatial experiences.

My initial assumption was that Manchester Chinatown would feel more Chinese due to its large Chinese archway, concentration of Chinese businesses and strong visual symbolism. However, after visiting London Chinatown, my perception changed. Despite having fewer monumental symbols, London Chinatown appeared to generate a stronger sense of immersion through pedestrianised streets, commercial density and continuous street-level activity. The experience reminded me of commercial pedestrian streets in Chinese cities such as Beijing Road in Guangzhou.

This observation became the starting point of the dissertation. Rather than asking whether either Chinatown is more authentically Chinese, the project seeks to understand how different urban environments produce different experiences of Chineseness and sense of place.

Research Questions

How is sense of place produced differently in London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown?

Sub-questions

How do spatial experiences differ between the two Chinatowns?

How do visual and linguistic elements contribute to the production of Chineseness?

How can autoethnographic observation help explain differences in perception between the two sites?

2. Literature Review

2.1 Sense of Place

The concept of sense of place provides the primary theoretical framework for this dissertation. Early studies established the foundations of the concept by emphasising the relationship between people and place. Relph (1976) argues that meaningful places generate attachment, identity and belonging, while Tuan (1977) suggests that place emerges through lived experience and human perception rather than physical form alone. Massey (1994) further develops these ideas by arguing that places are not fixed entities but are continuously produced through social, cultural and economic relationships.

More recent research has paid greater attention to how sense of place develops through everyday experience and movement. Manzo et al. (2023) connect people's relationships with place to experience, memory and periods of urban change. Movement is also important. Kołodyńska et al. (2025) examine the relationship between mobility and sense of place, while Eng and McCormack (2025) identify links between walkability and place attachment. These studies are useful for this research because both Chinatowns were experienced mainly through walking.

2.2 British Chinatown Studies

Studies of British Chinatowns provide an important context for this research because they show how Chinese identity is shaped within specific UK cities. Rather than treating Chinatown only as an ethnic enclave, this research also considers its relationship with migration, urban change and everyday city life.

Sales et al. (2011) examine London Chinatown through questions of diaspora, identity and belonging, showing that it has social and cultural roles beyond its commercial function. Barabantseva (2016), in contrast, places Manchester Chinatown within wider processes of migration and urban transformation. These two studies are particularly relevant here because they show that the identity of each Chinatown is connected to the city around it, rather than existing separately from it.

2.3 International Chinatown Case Studies

Recent studies suggest that Chinatowns should not be understood as a single urban model. Although they often share similar cultural symbols, their identities are shaped by different historical, social and spatial contexts. Comparing international examples demonstrates that Chineseness can be produced through different relationships between migration, commerce, heritage and everyday urban experience.

Kuala Lumpur Chinatown provides an example of how cultural identity can be produced through everyday street activity. Petaling Street is characterised by street trading, food, high pedestrian activity and a lively outdoor atmosphere. Tan and Aminuddin (2019) argue that these activities help sustain Chinatown as a living cultural enclave by supporting active street life and walkability. This suggests that the experience of Chineseness can emerge through repeated everyday activities rather than relying only on monumental cultural symbols.

Sydney Chinatown demonstrates a different relationship between cultural identity, redevelopment and tourism. Burke (2010) shows how the redevelopment of Chinatown used representations of Chinese tradition to construct a recognisable cultural environment, while also connecting these representations with tourism and the wider multicultural identity of Sydney. This case demonstrates how Chinatown identity can be actively shaped through urban redevelopment and cultural representation.

San Francisco Chinatown provides a further example of the relationship between architectural symbolism, heritage and cultural identity. Following its historical reconstruction, Chinese architectural elements such as pagodas and dragon motifs were used to reshape the image of the district and strengthen its visibility as Chinatown (Xie and Batunova, 2020). This demonstrates how cultural identity can be deliberately reinforced through architectural representation, while also becoming connected to tourism and heritage branding.

Together, these international examples demonstrate that there is no single spatial model for producing Chinatown identity. Chineseness may emerge through everyday street activity, cultural representation, architectural symbolism or combinations of these elements. These cases therefore provide a broader comparative context for

examining why London and Manchester Chinatowns produce different senses of place despite sharing similar cultural references.

These cases show that there is no single spatial model for Chinatown. In Kuala Lumpur, everyday commerce and pedestrian activity are particularly important, while Sydney shows the influence of redevelopment and tourism, and San Francisco demonstrates a stronger use of architectural symbolism. This wider context helps frame the comparison between London and Manchester without treating either place as a measure of authentic Chineseness.

2.4 Linguistic Landscape and Visual Identity

The concept of the linguistic landscape has become increasingly important in studies of ethnic neighbourhoods and multicultural cities. Originally defined by Landry and Bourhis (1997), the linguistic landscape refers to the visible use of language in public space, including street names, shop signs, advertisements and other written displays. These visual elements not only communicate practical information but also reflect the cultural, political and social identities of particular places. Consequently, linguistic landscapes have been widely adopted as a method for understanding how ethnic identity is expressed and negotiated within urban environments.

Recent studies have extended this concept beyond language itself to consider the broader visual identity of cities. Shohamy and Gorter (2009) argue that public signage should be understood as a form of spatial communication, revealing relationships between language, power and cultural representation. Rather than acting as passive labels, signs actively contribute to the production of place by shaping how spaces are interpreted and experienced by different users. From this perspective, bilingual signs, Chinese typography and culturally specific graphic elements become part of the everyday construction of Chinatown as an identifiable urban environment.

Within British Chinatowns, linguistic landscape research has largely focused on the visibility of Chinese language and bilingual communication. Harland et al. (2024) analyse the visual environment of London Chinatown, demonstrating that Chinese characters are consistently embedded within shopfronts, decorative elements and public signage throughout the district. Rather than functioning as isolated cultural symbols, these visual elements create a continuous streetscape in which Chinese

identity remains highly visible. Similarly, Matras and Gaiser (2016) argue that multilingual signage within Manchester reflects the city's linguistic diversity and illustrates how language contributes to both commercial activity and community identity.

These studies are useful for identifying how Chinese identity becomes visible in the street. However, documenting signs alone cannot fully explain how a Chinatown is experienced. Similar visual elements may feel quite different depending on where they appear, how often they are encountered and what is happening around them.

This limitation became particularly evident during the preliminary fieldwork for this dissertation. Before visiting London Chinatown, it seemed reasonable to assume that Manchester Chinatown would produce a stronger sense of Chineseness because of its monumental archway and concentrated visual symbolism. However, the walking experience suggested a different interpretation. Although London Chinatown contains fewer monumental landmarks, the continuous sequence of bilingual shopfronts, restaurants, street activity and pedestrianised public space created a stronger sense of spatial immersion. This observation suggests that visual identity cannot be understood independently from the spatial conditions through which it is encountered.

For this reason, linguistic landscape is considered together with movement and embodied experience in this dissertation. Chinese signs, menus and typography are recorded during the walks, but I also consider where they appear and how they are encountered. This makes it possible to examine linguistic landscape as part of the experience of Chinatown rather than only as a collection of visual symbols.

2.5 Autoethnography, Walking and Embodied Experience

Recent developments in qualitative urban research have increasingly challenged the dominance of detached, observational approaches to studying cities. Rather than treating researchers as objective observers positioned outside the environment, contemporary methodologies recognise that urban space is experienced through movement, perception and personal engagement. This shift has encouraged greater attention to embodied experience and has established walking as both a method of data collection and a way of understanding how places are encountered in everyday life.

Autoethnography is useful within this broader methodological approach because it allows the researcher's own experience to become part of the research material. Chang (2008) describes autoethnography as a qualitative method in which personal experience can provide analytical insight rather than remain as personal reflection. Ellis et al. (2011) similarly show how individual experiences can become research data when they are critically interpreted and connected to wider cultural and social contexts. In this research, personal experience is therefore used as evidence, but it is also questioned and interpreted alongside other forms of observation.

This approach is particularly relevant to the present research because the dissertation originated from a change in the researcher's own perception. Before conducting the fieldwork, Manchester Chinatown appeared likely to provide a stronger sense of Chineseness due to its iconic Chinese archway and concentrated symbolic identity. However, the walking experience in London Chinatown challenged this assumption. Rather than confirming the importance of visual landmarks, the fieldwork suggested that continuous pedestrian movement, commercial density and everyday street activity generated a stronger sense of immersion. This unexpected shift in perception became the starting point for the research and demonstrates why personal experience is not treated as bias to be eliminated, but as empirical evidence that requires critical explanation.

Walking is also important to this research because the city changes as it is experienced through time and movement. Ingold (2011) argues that knowledge can be produced through movement rather than observation alone. From this perspective, a place is not understood only through maps or its physical form, but through encounters with streets, buildings, sounds, people and changing spatial sequences. Walking can therefore reveal aspects of everyday urban life that may be difficult to identify through conventional mapping alone.

Pink (2015) similarly proposes that sensory ethnography offers opportunities to understand environments through multiple forms of perception rather than visual observation alone. Urban experiences are shaped by sounds, smells, crowd density, movement, temperature and emotional responses, all of which contribute to the production of place. For this reason, the present research records spoken reflections immediately during the walks instead of relying solely on photographs taken

afterwards. Voice recordings capture immediate reactions before they are influenced by later interpretation, preserving moments of surprise, familiarity and uncertainty that are central to understanding how sense of place develops during movement.

Walking and urban experience have also been explored through psychogeography. Debord (1958) introduced the dérive as a form of exploratory walking guided by the emotional and spatial qualities of the environment rather than by a fixed destination. This research does not fully adopt psychogeography, but this openness to unexpected encounters influenced the fieldwork. The routes through both Chinatowns were relatively unstructured, and decisions to stop, change direction or spend more time in particular places were often made during the walk. This allowed the environment itself to influence how the fieldwork developed.

This approach also influenced the decision not to use a traditional urban analysis framework as the main analytical tool. Lynch's (1960) concepts of paths, edges, districts, nodes and landmarks remain useful for describing and representing urban form. However, this dissertation is more concerned with what happens while moving through these spaces. Lynch's framework alone cannot fully explain why two Chinatowns with some similar physical characteristics may produce different emotional and sensory experiences. The research therefore uses mapping as supporting material while placing greater emphasis on walking and lived experience.

Bringing together autoethnography, walking and sensory observation enables this research to examine Chinatowns not simply as physical environments but as places that are continually produced through movement and interaction. Rather than separating visual identity from spatial experience, the study considers how commercial activity, linguistic landscapes, pedestrian movement and embodied perception work together to produce different senses of place. This integrated approach provides the methodological foundation for the comparative analysis presented in the following chapters.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This research uses a qualitative comparative case study to compare London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown. The main aim is to understand how sense of

place is experienced in the two Chinatowns through walking. Instead of measuring urban form or collecting quantitative data, the research focuses on everyday spatial experience and personal observation.

To do this, the project combines several methods, including literature review, walking, photography, voice recordings and autoethnographic reflection. These methods were chosen because they allow both the physical environment and personal experience to be considered together. Rather than treating personal experience as a limitation, this research uses it as part of the evidence to understand why the two Chinatowns feel different.

The research was carried out in several stages. First, the literature review was completed to identify the main theories related to sense of place, Chinatown studies and autoethnography. Fieldwork was then undertaken in London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown. During the visits, photographs and voice recordings were collected while walking through the sites. These materials were later reviewed and organised into several themes, which form the basis of the findings chapter.

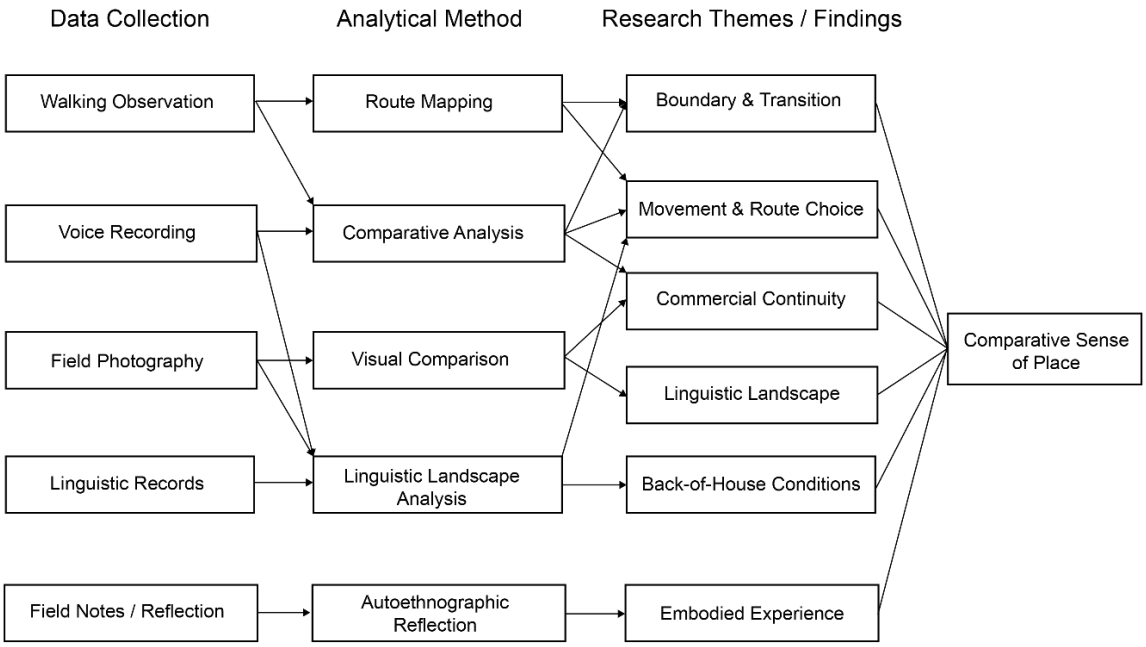


Figure 3.1. Research process showing the relationship between data collection, analytical methods and the key themes used to examine sense of place in London and Manchester Chinatowns.

Source: Author, 2026.

3.2 Case Study Selection

London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown were selected because they are two of the best-known Chinatowns in England, but they feel quite different when walking through them. Both have Chinese restaurants, supermarkets and other Chinese businesses, but their urban environments are organised differently.

London Chinatown is located in Soho and is made up of several pedestrian-friendly streets with continuous commercial activity. Manchester Chinatown is centred around the Chinese archway and has a more open street layout. These differences made them suitable for comparison.

The purpose of choosing these two case studies is not to decide which Chinatown is more authentic or more Chinese. Instead, the comparison focuses on how different spatial environments create different experiences of place. It is hoped that comparing the two sites will help explain why they produce different feelings even though they contain many similar elements.

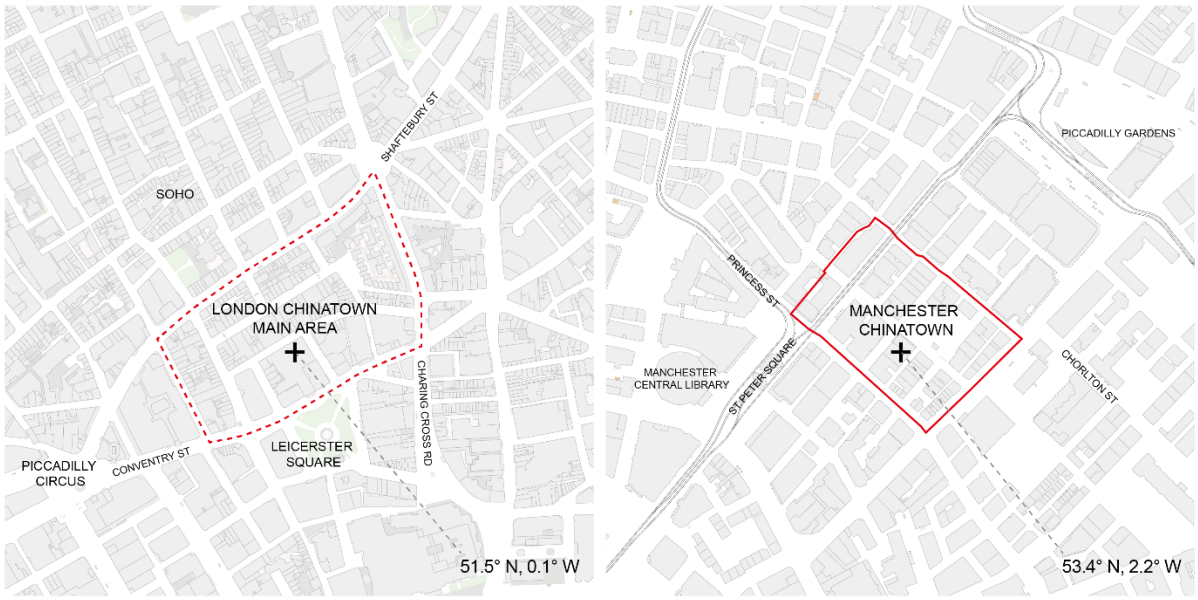


Figure 3.2. Location of London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown within the United Kingdom.

Source: Mapping by author, 2026; base map adapted from Digimap.

3.3 Fieldwork and Walking Methodology

The main fieldwork method used in this research was walking. Instead of following a fixed route, I walked through both Chinatowns and recorded my observations during

the process. This made it possible to notice unexpected details and compare how the two places were experienced.

During each visit, I paid attention to things such as street layout, pedestrian movement, commercial activity and visual identity. Whenever something stood out, I recorded a short voice note or took a photograph. These recordings were made immediately so that my first impressions were not forgotten afterwards.

The walks were not designed to collect every piece of information in a systematic way. Instead, they were intended to understand the overall experience of being in each Chinatown. This approach fits the autoethnographic method introduced earlier and provides the main evidence for the findings chapter.

3.4 Data Collection

Three types of data were collected during the fieldwork: voice recordings, photographs and short field notes. These were collected in both London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown during the site visits.

Voice recordings were the main source of data because they captured my first reactions while walking. Instead of writing notes afterwards, I recorded short comments whenever I noticed something interesting or when my impression of the space changed. This helped keep the observations as natural as possible.

Photographs were taken to record streets, shopfronts, signs and other physical features. Rather than documenting every street, I mainly photographed places that related to my observations or supported the voice recordings.

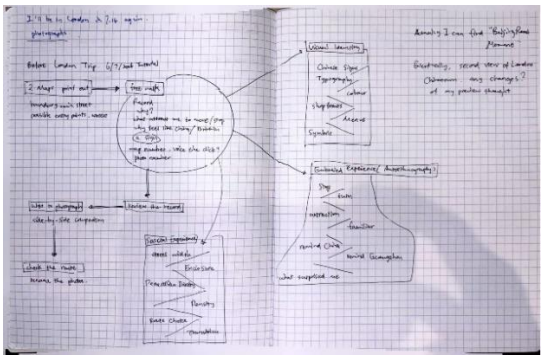
After each visit, I also wrote a few field notes to summarise the overall experience. These notes were useful for organising the material before starting the analysis.



(a)



(b)



(c)

Figure 3.4. Fieldwork documentation and recording process: (a) handwritten preparation notes identifying key observation themes; (b) real-time voice recording and transcription during the London Chinatown walk; and (c) preliminary route tracing used to reconstruct the fieldwork route.

Source: Author's fieldwork records, 2026.

3.5 Data Analysis

After the fieldwork, the voice recordings, photographs and field notes were reviewed together. Instead of deciding the themes before visiting the sites, I looked through the material several times to see what patterns appeared.

During this process, a number of similar observations appeared in both case studies. For example, I noticed differences in how people entered Chinatown, how they moved through the streets and how commercial activities were organised. Visual identity and my own walking experience also appeared repeatedly in the recordings.

Based on these observations, the findings chapter is organised into five themes: Boundary and Transition, Movement and Route Choice, Commercial Continuity, Linguistic Landscape and Visual Identity, and Embodied Experience. These themes were chosen because they appeared most often during the fieldwork and seem to explain the main differences between the two Chinatowns.

At this stage, the analysis mainly focuses on describing and comparing these themes. The wider discussion and connections with the literature will be developed in the following chapter.

3.6 Fieldwork Process

The fieldwork was conducted in London Chinatown on 14 July 2026 and Manchester Chinatown on 21 July 2026, both between approximately 18:00 and 19:00. Using the same weekday and time period helped reduce differences in pedestrian activity, commercial activity and evening atmosphere. The walks remained open-ended, allowing unexpected spatial and sensory encounters to influence the observations.

Before each visit, a preliminary route was marked on a map to identify possible entry points and key streets. The route was used only as a guide, allowing me to change direction, stop or spend more time in particular locations. Photographs and voice recordings were collected during the walks to document these observations.

In London Chinatown, the walk focused on the transition from Soho into the district, particularly changes in Chinese businesses, bilingual signs, pedestrian activity and commercial frontage. Attention was given to how these elements gradually became more noticeable and contributed to a stronger sense of immersion while moving towards the commercial core.

In Manchester Chinatown, the walk focused on the relationship between the Chinese archway, the main commercial streets and the surrounding city-centre environment. Attention was given to how Chinese businesses and visual markers were encountered along the route and how their presence changed when moving away from the central area.

During both visits, voice recordings were used to capture immediate reactions to atmosphere, movement, visual details and moments of familiarity or surprise. These recordings were later reviewed alongside photographs and route observations as part of the comparative analysis.

Personal reactions were not treated as conclusions on their own. Instead, they were compared with photographs, route observations and relevant literature to understand how specific spatial conditions influenced perception. This allowed autoethnographic experience to contribute to the analysis without becoming its sole basis.

4. Findings

4.1 Boundary and Transition

One of the first differences I noticed during the fieldwork was how each Chinatown begins. Although both are located within busy city centres, entering the two places feels quite different. The boundary is not only a physical edge but also something experienced while walking.

In London Chinatown, I found it difficult to identify one single moment when I had clearly entered the district. Chinese restaurants, supermarkets and bilingual signs appeared gradually while moving through Soho, rather than beginning at one fixed boundary. The change became noticeable through a combination of increasing commercial activity, Chinese-language signs and a busier pedestrian environment. Because of this, the experience of entering Chinatown happened progressively. I

became aware that the character of the street was changing before I could identify a specific point that could be described as the entrance.

This gradual change may help explain why London Chinatown felt more immersive during the walk. Instead of encountering one large element that announced the entrance, the identity of Chinatown developed through a series of smaller changes in the street environment. Restaurants, signs, pedestrians and commercial activities appeared more frequently as the route moved further into the area. In this sense, the boundary was experienced through accumulation rather than through a single object. This relates to Massey's (1994) understanding of place as something produced through ongoing social and spatial relationships rather than as a fixed container with clearly defined edges.

In London, the transition into Chinatown was also reinforced by a change in the use of the street itself. During the walk, a smaller Chinese-style gateway appeared close to the entrance of a pedestrianised street. This created a threshold that was both visual and spatial: Chinese architectural imagery marked the cultural identity of the area, while the reduction of vehicular movement changed the way the street could be experienced. The entrance therefore did not operate only as a symbolic marker, but also as a transition from the surrounding traffic environment towards a more pedestrian-oriented Chinatown.

Manchester Chinatown created a more immediate sense of arrival. The large Chinese archway acts as a strong visual marker and makes the identity of the area clear before the route has fully entered the main commercial streets. During the walk, this produced a different type of transition from London. Rather than gradually noticing a change in the surrounding environment, the archway provided a recognisable point that signalled Chinatown almost instantly. The boundary therefore felt more concentrated around a symbolic landmark, giving the entrance a stronger visual presence within the wider city-centre environment.



Figure 4.1.1. Small Chinese-style gateway and the transition into the pedestrianised street in London Chinatown, illustrating the relationship between cultural symbolism and pedestrian movement.

Source: Photographs by author, 14 July 2026.

The importance of the archway can be understood within the wider urban context of Manchester Chinatown. Unlike London Chinatown, which is located within the highly active commercial environment of Soho and the West End, Manchester Chinatown is positioned within Manchester city centre as a distinct cultural district. The gateway therefore plays an important role in making the presence of Chinatown visible within the wider urban landscape.

However, after passing through the gateway, the experience becomes less continuous. Chinese businesses are still present, but they are interrupted more often by other buildings and urban functions. This creates a difference between recognising Chinatown and experiencing Chinatown. The area can be immediately identified through its symbolic marker, but the feeling of being immersed within a Chinese commercial environment becomes less consistent during the walk.

This observation relates to Barabantseva's (2016) argument that Manchester Chinatown should not be understood as an isolated ethnic enclave, but as a place embedded within wider processes of urban transformation and city-making. The fieldwork suggests that its identity is produced partly through symbolic representation

within the city rather than through continuous spatial separation from the surrounding urban environment.



Figure 4.1.2. Boundary and Transition Conditions in (a) London and (b) Manchester Chinatowns.

Source: Adapted from Chinatown London and Manchester City Council; boundary and transition analysis based on fieldwork by author, 2026.

The two Chinatowns therefore create boundaries differently. In London, identity develops through gradual changes in street activity and visual elements, while in Manchester the archway provides a more immediate and concentrated marker of cultural identity.

The difference is therefore not the amount of Chinese cultural elements, but how they are encountered within the wider city. London Chinatown is experienced more

gradually through movement, while Manchester Chinatown is recognised more immediately through symbolic presence.

4.2 Movement and Route Choice

Walking through the two Chinatowns revealed clear differences in how movement was shaped by the surrounding urban environment. Although both areas are compact and walkable, the routes developed differently in response to street layout, commercial activity and visual landmarks.

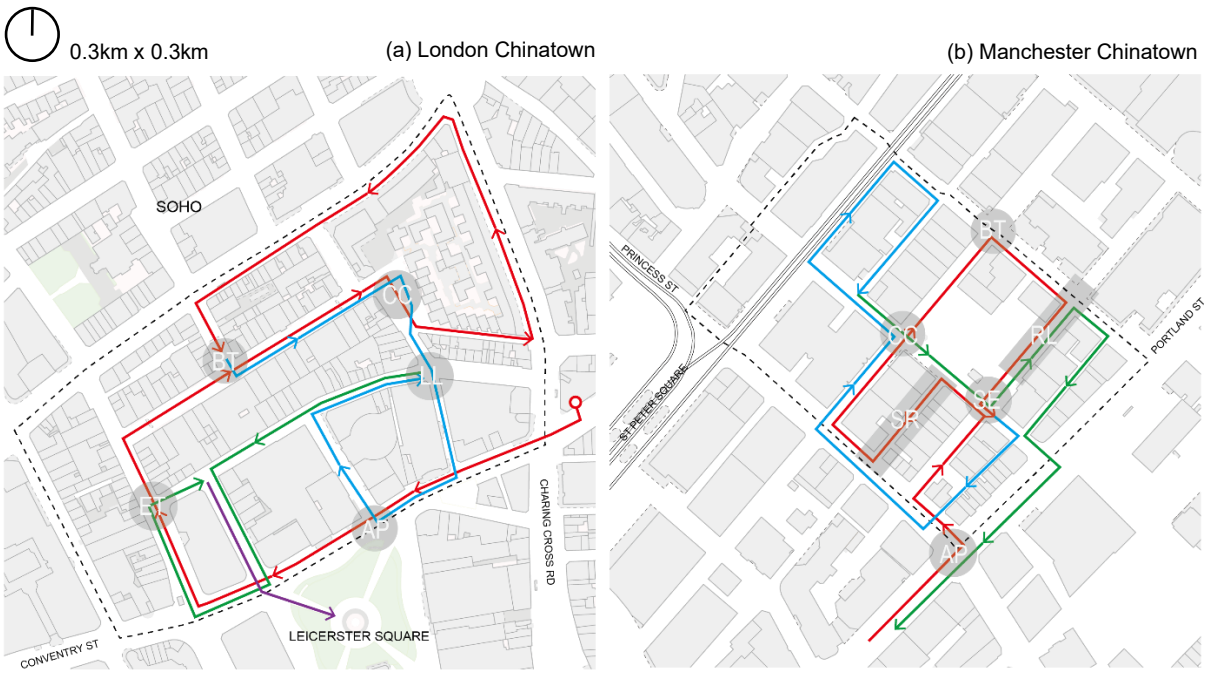


Figure 4.2. Walking Routes and Key Observation Points in London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown. (a) London Chinatown fieldwork route, 14 July 2026. (b) Manchester Chinatown fieldwork route, 21 July 2026.

Observation zones: AP = Approach; ET = Entrance / Transition; CC = Commercial Core; LL = Linguistic Landscape; BT = Boundary Transition; SR = Service / Rear Street.

Source: Mapping by author, 2026; base map adapted from Digimap.

In London Chinatown, movement developed in a relatively exploratory way. Entering from Leicester Square, I moved towards Wardour Street and Gerrard Street before continuing through Newport Place and nearby streets. Restaurants, shopfronts, Chinese signage and pedestrian activity frequently influenced where I stopped or changed direction, making the route less destination-oriented.

The continuous commercial environment encouraged further exploration, while changes near the edges of Chinatown made the boundary more noticeable. As

Chinese signage and commercial activity became less frequent towards Soho, the transition out of Chinatown was experienced gradually through movement rather than at a clearly defined edge.

The pedestrianised streets also shaped the walking experience by allowing greater freedom to slow down, stop and change direction in response to shopfronts, signs and street activity. This made the route more exploratory and helped strengthen the sense of immersion within London Chinatown.

In Manchester Chinatown, the route approached from Princess Street, passed the Chinese archway and continued through Faulkner Street and the main commercial area before extending into surrounding and rear streets. The walk then returned towards the archway.

Compared with London, movement in Manchester was more strongly organised around landmarks and specific streets. The archway remained a clear point of orientation, while Chinese businesses and signs were concentrated around particular areas. Moving away from these locations made the wider city-centre environment more visible and reduced the continuity of the Chinatown experience.

Figure 4.2 shows that movement in London was more exploratory, supported by interconnected pedestrian streets and continuous commercial activity. In Manchester, movement was more strongly oriented around the archway and concentrated commercial areas. These different movement patterns influenced how each Chinatown was experienced during the walk.

4.3 Commercial Continuity

Commercial activity was present in both Chinatowns, but its spatial continuity differed. Although both contained Chinese restaurants, supermarkets and cafés, these uses were organised differently and produced distinct experiences while walking.

In London Chinatown, commercial uses form a relatively continuous sequence along the pedestrian streets. Restaurants, bakeries, supermarkets and other businesses are closely connected, creating active frontages throughout much of the walk. Food displays, menus and shop windows frequently encouraged me to slow down or stop, linking pedestrian movement with everyday commercial activity.

This continuity contributed to a stronger sense of immersion because Chinese-related activities were repeatedly encountered rather than concentrated around a few locations. The relationship between active frontages, pedestrian movement and commercial activity therefore became part of the experience of Chinatown itself.



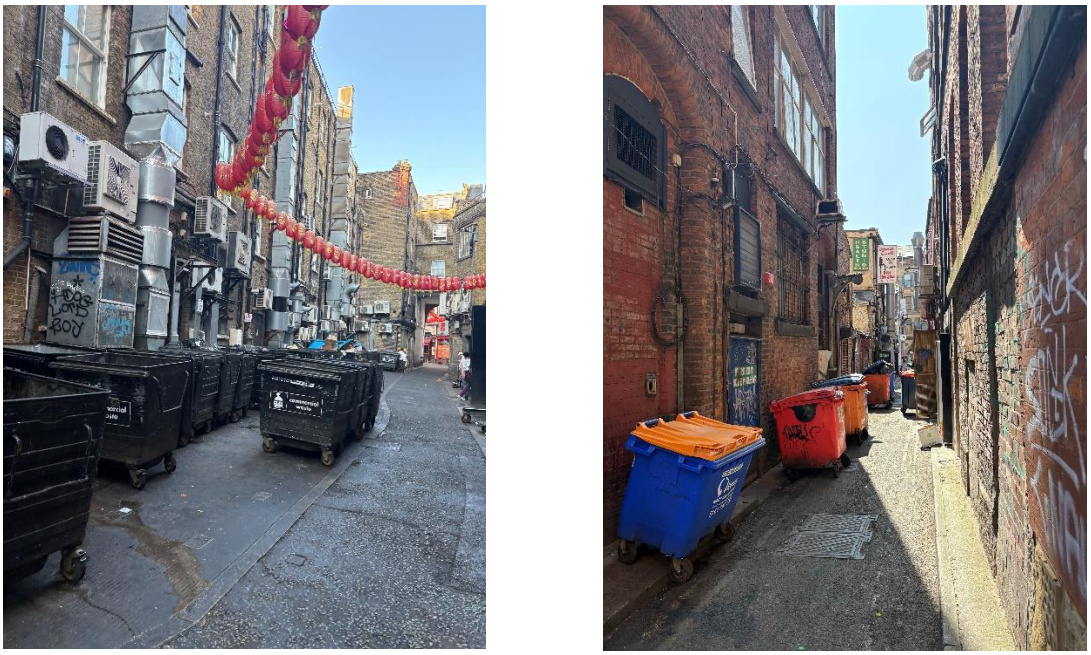
(a) (b)

Figure 4.3. Street-level commercial activity in London and Manchester Chinatowns: (a) London Chinatown; (b) Manchester Chinatown. The photographs document shopfronts, outdoor seating and pedestrian use observed during the fieldwork.

Source: Photographs by author, 14 and 21 July 2026.

Manchester Chinatown presented a more concentrated pattern. Chinese restaurants and businesses remained important, but offices, residential buildings and unrelated uses became more visible between them. Chinatown therefore felt strongest around particular streets and locations. This does not indicate a weaker cultural identity, but a different spatial organisation in which recognition depends more on concentrated commercial areas and prominent cultural markers.

The comparison suggests that commercial activity contributes to sense of place through its spatial arrangement as well as its function. In London, greater continuity strengthened the relationship between commerce, pedestrian movement and street life, while in Manchester commercial identity was more concentrated.



(a) (b)

Figure 4.3.1. Back-of-house conditions observed in London and Manchester Chinatowns: (a) London Chinatown; (b) Manchester Chinatown, showing waste storage, service infrastructure and rear street conditions.

Source: Photographs by author, 14 and 21 July 2026.

The fieldwork also revealed similar back-of-house conditions in both Chinatowns. Secondary and rear streets contained waste storage, service entrances, ventilation equipment and other infrastructure associated with dense restaurant and retail activity. These functions were often directly visible from the street, creating a clear contrast with the more carefully presented commercial frontages. Rather than treating waste itself as evidence of poor environmental quality, the observation raises a spatial question about how servicing requirements are integrated into compact commercial districts.

This front-to-back contrast also formed part of the walking experience. Chinatown was encountered through both curated cultural frontages and the ordinary infrastructure required to support them, showing that sense of place is shaped by everyday urban processes as well as visible cultural representation.

4.4 Linguistic Landscape and Visual Identity

The linguistic landscape was another important aspect observed during the fieldwork. Both London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown contain Chinese

characters, bilingual signs, restaurant menus and culturally recognisable visual elements. Although these forms of Chinese visibility appear in both places, their distribution and relationship with the surrounding streets create different experiences while walking.

In London Chinatown, Chinese language appeared continuously throughout the walking experience. Chinese characters, English translations, restaurant names and commercial graphics were repeatedly encountered across shopfronts and streets. These elements were not experienced as isolated signs, but as part of a wider visual environment shaped by active frontages, pedestrian movement and commercial activity. As a result, Chinese identity remained visible across much of the route rather than being concentrated at a small number of locations.

This observation connects with Harland et al. (2024), who highlight the importance of heritage language and graphic elements in constructing the visual identity of London Chinatown. The fieldwork suggests that the significance of these elements comes not only from their presence, but also from their spatial continuity. Repeated encounters with Chinese signage helped create a more consistent visual environment and strengthened the sense of immersion experienced during the walk.

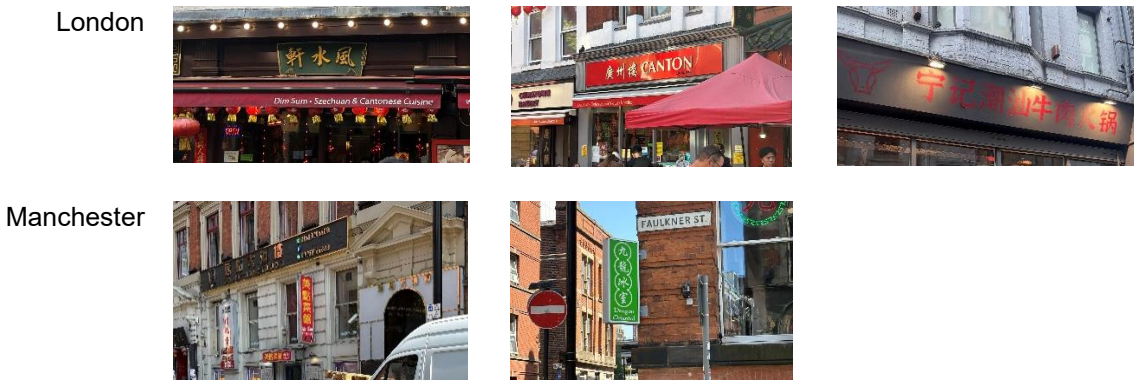


Figure 4.4. Linguistic landscapes observed in London and Manchester Chinatowns, showing differences in the continuity and visibility of Chinese-language signage, bilingual street signs and commercial shopfronts.

Source: Photographs by author, 14 and 21 July 2026.

Manchester Chinatown also contained clear linguistic and visual markers. Chinese street signs, restaurant names and the Chinese archway communicated the identity of the district quickly. However, these elements appeared more concentrated around particular locations. As I moved away from the central streets, Chinese-language

signs became less frequent and the wider Manchester city-centre environment became more visible. The linguistic landscape therefore felt strongest around specific points rather than continuously across the route.

The comparison suggests that the effect of linguistic landscape depends not only on how many signs are present, but also on where they appear and how they are encountered through movement. Manchester produced stronger recognition through concentrated visual markers, while London created a more continuous visual experience through repeated encounters with Chinese language, shopfronts and commercial activity.

Linguistic landscape in this research is therefore more than a collection of signs or symbols. It forms part of the wider spatial experience through which a visitor recognises, interprets and remembers Chinatown. The fieldwork suggests that Chinese identity is shaped not only by what is visible in the street, but also by the sequence, repetition and spatial context in which these visual elements are encountered while moving through the area.

4.5 Embodied Experience

Beyond the physical characteristics of the two Chinatowns, the fieldwork also revealed the importance of embodied experience in understanding sense of place. Through walking, the research did not only record visible elements such as buildings, signs and commercial activities, but also considered how the environment influenced feelings, memories and perceptions during movement.

One of the most significant moments during the fieldwork occurred in London Chinatown. While walking through the streets, I unexpectedly associated the experience with pedestrian commercial streets in Chinese cities, particularly Beijing Road in Guangzhou. This connection was not based on direct architectural similarity. Instead, it appeared to emerge from a combination of factors, including continuous shopfronts, pedestrian activity, food culture and the rhythm of everyday street life.

This experience became an important example of why autoethnography is relevant to this research. The purpose is not to suggest that London Chinatown is identical to a Chinese commercial street, but rather to examine how certain spatial qualities can trigger memories and feelings associated with previous urban experiences. As Tuan

(1977) argues, places are not understood only through physical characteristics but through human experience, memory and perception.

During the London walk, the continuous sequence of streets and commercial activities encouraged a stronger sense of familiarity. I found myself slowing down, observing details and spending more time within the environment than originally planned. These reactions were recorded through voice notes during the walk and later reviewed as part of the analysis process.

The experience in Manchester Chinatown developed differently. The Chinese archway created an immediate recognition of place and established a strong cultural identity at the entrance. However, while continuing through the area, the feeling of immersion became less consistent. The district remained recognisably Chinatown, but the surrounding urban environment became increasingly visible, shifting attention away from the Chinese commercial landscape.

This contrast suggests that sense of place is not only created through recognition but also through continued engagement. Manchester Chinatown demonstrates how symbolic elements can quickly communicate cultural identity, while London Chinatown demonstrates how repeated everyday encounters can gradually create emotional connection and spatial familiarity.

These observations still represent one specific autoethnographic perspective rather than an experience that can be applied to every visitor. Someone with a different cultural background, memory or expectation may respond to the same streets in another way. The value of this method therefore does not come from claiming one objective interpretation. Instead, it shows how particular spatial conditions can interact with individual memories and experiences to influence the way a place is perceived.

Overall, the fieldwork suggests that embodied experience provides an additional layer for understanding British Chinatowns. While visual symbols and commercial activities establish recognisable identities, the feeling of belonging or immersion emerges through the relationship between movement, memory and everyday encounters within the urban environment.

4.6 Chapter Summary

This chapter presented the findings from the fieldwork conducted in London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown. Through walking observation, photography and voice recordings, five themes were identified: boundary and transition, movement and route choice, commercial continuity, linguistic landscape and embodied experience.

The comparison suggests that the two Chinatowns produce different experiences of place despite containing many similar cultural elements. London Chinatown appears to generate a stronger sense of immersion through gradual transition, continuous commercial activity and everyday pedestrian experience. In contrast, Manchester Chinatown creates a stronger initial recognition through symbolic elements such as the Chinese archway, but the experience becomes less continuous during movement through the wider area.

These findings suggest that Chineseness within urban environments is not produced by cultural symbols alone. Instead, it emerges through the relationship between visual identity, spatial organisation, commercial activity and everyday experience.

The following chapter discusses these findings in relation to the wider literature and considers how different urban contexts influence the production of sense of place in British Chinatowns.

5. Discussion

5.1 From Symbolic Identity to Spatial Experience

The findings suggest that the difference between London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown is not simply a difference in the amount of Chinese cultural representation. Instead, the two cases demonstrate different ways in which Chineseness can be produced and experienced through urban space. Similar cultural elements are present in both places, but their spatial arrangement, continuity and relationship with pedestrian movement influence how strongly they are perceived during everyday walking.

Manchester Chinatown is strongly associated with symbolic representation. The Chinese archway creates an immediate visual marker and gives the district a clear

cultural identity within Manchester city centre. During the fieldwork, this made Chinatown easy to recognise from the beginning of the walk. However, recognition did not always produce the same level of immersion throughout the wider area. Once beyond the archway and the main commercial streets, Chinese businesses, signs and other cultural references became less continuous, while the surrounding city-centre environment became more visible. The symbolic identity of Chinatown therefore remained strong, but its spatial presence varied as the route developed.

London Chinatown appears to operate differently. Rather than depending on one dominant landmark, its identity develops through a sequence of everyday encounters. Commercial frontages, pedestrian movement, bilingual signs, food displays and street activity are repeatedly experienced while walking through the area. No single element is responsible for producing the sense of Chinatown. Instead, these elements reinforce one another through repetition and continuity, allowing cultural identity to emerge gradually over time and through movement. This helps explain why London produced a stronger sense of immersion despite having fewer dominant monumental symbols.

This difference can be understood through wider sense of place literature. Massey (1994) argues that places are not fixed containers of identity but are continually produced through social relationships and connections. The findings from the two Chinatowns support this view while also showing that the spatial organisation of these relationships matters. Cultural references may be visually similar, but their effect changes depending on whether they are encountered as isolated markers or as part of a continuous sequence of streets, businesses and activities. Sense of place is therefore shaped not only by what is present, but also by how these elements are encountered through movement.

The comparison points to a useful distinction between symbolic Chineseness and experiential Chineseness. Symbolic Chineseness is communicated through recognisable elements such as gateways, signs and architectural references, allowing cultural identity to be identified quickly. Experiential Chineseness develops more gradually through repeated encounters with commercial activity, language, pedestrian movement and everyday street life. These two forms are not separate or

mutually exclusive. Both are present in London and Manchester, but their relative balance differs between the two sites.

This distinction helps explain the main contrast identified during the fieldwork. Manchester Chinatown produces a strong moment of cultural recognition through concentrated symbolic elements, while London Chinatown produces a more continuous sense of engagement through the accumulation of smaller everyday experiences. The comparison therefore suggests that the production of Chineseness depends not only on visible cultural representation, but also on the spatial and temporal conditions through which that representation is experienced.

5.2 The Influence of Urban Context

The findings also demonstrate that Chinatown identity cannot be separated from the wider urban context in which each district exists.

London Chinatown sits within Soho and the West End, where tourism, entertainment and pedestrian activity are already important parts of the wider urban environment. This context contributes to the busy and continuous street life experienced during the fieldwork. Chinatown is therefore supported not only by its internal shops, signs and businesses, but also by its position within a part of central London where walking, leisure and street-level commercial activity are already highly visible.

Manchester Chinatown operates within a different city-centre condition. The archway and concentration of Chinese businesses give the district a strong cultural presence, but these elements exist alongside offices, residential buildings and other urban functions. During the walk, this made Chinatown feel more like a distinct cultural layer within the wider city than a continuously separate environment. Its identity remained recognisable, but became less dominant when moving away from the main streets and symbolic landmarks.

This comparison suggests that Chinatown should not be analysed only through what happens inside its apparent boundary. The streets, functions and urban character surrounding the district also affect how it is entered, navigated and experienced. Similar cultural elements may therefore produce different senses of place depending on the wider spatial context in which they appear. This helps explain why the same

type of sign, business or architectural reference can have a different effect in London and Manchester.

5.3 Rethinking Chineseness Through Sense of Place

The comparison between London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown challenges the idea that Chineseness can be understood simply through the number of visible Chinese elements present in a place. Both areas contain Chinese signs, restaurants, cultural references and recognisable symbols, yet they produce different experiences during walking. The difference appears to come from how these elements are arranged, repeated and encountered within the wider street environment.

The research suggests that Chineseness is better understood as a spatial experience rather than a fixed visual identity. It is produced through the interaction between cultural symbols, commercial practices, movement patterns and personal memories.

This perspective also helps explain why London Chinatown created an association with pedestrian commercial streets in Guangzhou during the fieldwork. The connection did not come from direct architectural similarity. Instead, it appeared through a combination of spatial qualities, including commercial density, pedestrian movement, food culture and the rhythm of everyday street activity. These similarities triggered an existing urban memory, showing how the experience of one place can be shaped partly through memories of other places.

Therefore, British Chinatowns should not be evaluated according to how closely they reproduce Chinese urban forms. Instead, they should be understood as unique urban spaces where Chinese identity is continuously negotiated through local histories, city contexts and everyday experiences.

6. Conclusion

This dissertation explored how sense of place is produced within British Chinatowns through a comparative study of London Chinatown and Manchester Chinatown. Rather than understanding Chinatowns only as ethnic enclaves or collections of Chinese cultural symbols, this research examined how Chineseness is experienced

through everyday spatial conditions, including movement, commercial activity, linguistic visibility and personal perception.

Through walking-based fieldwork, photography and autoethnographic reflection, several differences became clear between the two case studies. In London Chinatown, a stronger sense of immersion developed through continuous commercial frontages, pedestrian activity and the gradual transition from the surrounding urban environment. Rather than depending on one dominant cultural symbol, its identity was experienced through repeated encounters with businesses, signs, food and everyday street activity while moving through the area.

In contrast, Manchester Chinatown demonstrates a different relationship between cultural identity and urban space. The Chinese archway and concentrated Chinese businesses provide a strong symbolic representation of Chinatown within Manchester city centre. However, the walking experience suggests that this identity becomes less continuous beyond key locations, resulting in a stronger sense of recognition than immersion.

These differences show that Chineseness in urban space cannot be understood only as a fixed visual condition. In both case studies, cultural identity emerged through relationships between symbols, spatial organisation, commercial practices and embodied experience. The balance between these elements was different in each city. Manchester relied more strongly on symbolic visibility, while London developed a more continuous experience through everyday movement and street activity.

The study also shows how autoethnographic walking can contribute to this type of urban research. Personal responses and memories were not treated as conclusions on their own, but were considered together with photographs, route observations and spatial analysis. The association between London Chinatown and pedestrian commercial streets in China was particularly useful in showing how the experience of a present environment can interact with memories of places encountered previously.

However, this research also has limitations. The fieldwork reflects a specific individual experience and does not represent the perceptions of all visitors or residents. Future research could expand this approach by including interviews, longer-term observations and comparisons with additional Chinatowns in different cultural contexts.

From an urban design perspective, the findings highlight the role of ordinary spatial conditions in shaping the experience of cultural districts. Pedestrian movement, active frontages, street transitions and commercial activities may contribute as much as prominent architectural symbols to the creation of a recognisable sense of place. Cultural identity is therefore shaped not only by what is designed to represent it, but also by how streets are used and experienced in everyday life.

Overall, this study suggests that Chinatowns should be understood not only as cultural districts but as evolving urban spaces where identity is continuously produced through the relationship between people, place and everyday experience.

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